

Introduction to this effective practice guide

This effective practice guide introduces individual learning plans (ILPs) and is essential reading for practitioners, managers and those supporting the CPD process. The ILP plays a central role in ensuring that assessment outcomes inform teaching and learning.

The guide covers:

1. The features and purposes of the ILP
2. Benefits
3. Activities

What is an individual learning plan?

An effective individual learning plan (ILP) is at the heart of assessment, learning, support and achievement. It helps the learner to become an active, motivated partner in learning. The ILP is:

- a personalised, flexible route map to guide each learner's journey
- a dynamic working document, owned and used by the learner, supported by teachers, employers and others
- a record of learning goals and progression routes, initial and diagnostic assessment information, learning targets, progress and achievements within different contexts for learning
- a communication aid between the learner and others who support the learning process in various contexts
- a way of making and reinforcing links and connections between topics, subject and personal, learning and thinking skills.

In practice, this means learners using their ILP to:

- record what they want to achieve on their learning journey – their goals and progression options
- negotiate and plan **exactly** what they are going
- to do, how and when. The ILP will include:
 - learning targets with outcomes and timescales, and details of how success will be determined (success criteria)
 - details of the resources, support and guidance the learner will use
 - details of where and how the learning will take place.
- view every assessment as a learning opportunity and to plan for their next steps
- reflect on:
 - what, and how, they learned
 - what went well and why

- what went less well and why
- where they could use the skills and approaches again.

The benefits of ILPs

Learners can use ILPs to:

- take ownership of their own learning
- recognise the value of prior experiences
- make sense of new experiences and understand how they learn
- plan to practise skills and gain confidence by applying them in a range of different contexts such as the workplace, at home or in the community
- identify and understand barriers to learning, and where they can find support to remove them
- measure their own success.

Staff can use ILPs to:

- listen to learners' voices, review performance and respond to learners' needs
- integrate processes around the learner: initial and diagnostic assessment, action planning, learner contracts, additional support needs, tutorial records, learner performance, progression options and exit information
- match teaching and learning to learners' strengths and needs, and ensure that learners are on the right programmes and achieving according to expectations
- plan opportunities for learners to extend their learning into contexts such as the workplace, community or leisure activities
- plan opportunities for progression to further learning.

Managers can use ILPs to:

- make efficient use of core processes
- evaluate learners' responses to new teaching and learning approaches
- support consistent standards and sustainable improvement
- monitor the quality of provision and provide data for impact measures.

The learner's journey is dynamic, not confined to a simple loop. Learners will pass through several cycles of learning and review. Involve learners by encouraging them to ask questions about their learning. As you negotiate meaningful ILPs with learners, your role is to:

- create a climate in which learners can negotiate and contribute to their own learning plans
- use teaching approaches that make learning skills explicit

- provide constructive feedback and support for learners as they develop reflection skills.

Your role will vary from the 'sage on the stage' to the 'guide on the side' as learners gain skills and become independent.

Try this ...

- Ask learners to construct a 'route map' and develop ways of discussing learning experiences. For example: start, services, accelerate, destination, motorways, breakdowns.

Preparing to learn

- Share learning objectives and success criteria with learners in a language that they will be able to understand. Learners need to know and understand their targets if the ILP is to be an effective tool.
- With learners, create bite-sized, personal learning targets and success criteria. Learners record them in their ILP. They manage the tasks, measure their progress and reflect on what they learned and how they learned it.

Building assessment into teaching and learning

- Create frequent assessment and feedback opportunities.
- Use tasks where learners must ask questions to promote thinking.
- Plan your questioning strategy and engage all learners. For example, use diagnostic questions (why?, how? with 'wait' time. Ask pairs/groups to confer and agree an answer. Put questions to named individuals so that they are invited to contribute or respond.

Monitoring learning and giving feedback

- Develop error-marking checklists with learners, agreeing how errors will be recorded. Ask learners to mark their own or each other's work.
- Use self- and peer assessment with learners so they learn how to judge their own progress against the success criteria.
- Be specific in your feedback. Identify what has been done well and make specific suggestions for improvement.

Reflection and review

- Reflect on the skills used to learn and not just the content.

Note:

We use 'teaching and learning' and 'teacher' as generic terms to include:

Teaching and Learning

Effective practice guide

Individual learning plans



- teaching, training and learning;
- teachers, tutors, trainers, lecturers and instructors in the further education (FE) system.

These guides are designed to support effective practice in teaching and learning, and may be used with and by Teaching and Learning Coaches. For more information on implementing the Teaching and Learning Coach programme please see the Excellence Gateway:

<http://www.excellencegateway.org.uk/node/21613>.

Redeveloped from earlier resources on the Excellence Gateway:

<http://sflip.excellencegateway.org.uk/resources/assessmentguidance.aspx>

